

Automobiles are mostly now software. So, we are able to attract a lot of women"

SUMAN MISHRA
MD & CEO, MAHINDRA LAST MILE MOBILITY



We've tried creating safer spaces for women to work and increase employment in whatever way we can"

AANCHAL JAIN
CEO, PMI ELECTRO MOBILITY

ness built bus bodies in Haryana. The transition to electric mobility offered an opportunity to move up the value chain and enter a market dominated by automakers with expertise in internal combustion engines (ICE). "Pretty much everybody knew how to assemble a bus, and we knew that very well. That's how we took the plunge—a leap of faith—and decided to become an electric bus OEM ourselves," she says.

Cut to 2026: PMI Electro Mobility pipped legacy automakers such as Tata Motors and Ashok Leyland to bag the largest order—5,210 electric buses—under the ₹10,900-crore PM E-Drive scheme. It also won an order for around 1,200 buses under the PM-eBus Sewa Scheme. The e-bus maker currently has an order book of 7,500 buses.

For M&M's Mishra, too, the decision to go all-in on electric mobility helped the company establish its dominance in the last-mile mobility segment. When she took over as CEO in 2021, the business had a small electric three-wheeler presence alongside its ICE portfolio. With limited resources, she had to decide where to focus. "The future was electric," she says. "I thought that's where you have to focus because, first of all, it is something new. You are having a technology shift. And technology shift can always help you win, get leadership," she explains.

Mishra says Mahindra Last Mile Mobility's monthly electric three-wheeler sales have risen from 200-300 when she took over to 15,000-16,000 today.

Electrification is changing the nature of work in an industry where women have historically been scarce, particularly on factory floors. Mishra says electric vehicles are helping companies attract women to roles that were once harder to fill. Software, electronics and, increasingly, automated manufacturing processes are creating new entry points.

"Automobiles are mostly now software. So, we are able to attract a lot of women," she says. "If you are getting women in the product development side, you know you can get women in the service side because debugging is also now technically a lot more application-oriented and software-driven."

At Mahindra Last Mile Mobility, the change is visible on the shop floor as well. The battery line at its Zaheerabad plant has an all-women first shift. The Haridwar plant has a battery line staffed by women. Women also work in the company's battery assembly operations in Bengaluru. Women are 13% of the workforce of 1,100-1,200 people, up from 10% two years ago, says Mishra. The absolute numbers have risen by 30-40% annually over the past two years. "Because of electrification, the barrier is slowly dissipating," she adds.

Jain has adopted a similar approach at PMI Electro. The company runs an all-women battery assembly plant in Dharuhera and employs women in wiring-harness manufacturing. "We've tried creating safer spaces for women to work and increase employment in whatever way we can," she says. "We encourage women employment. Gender equality is one of the core pillars we work on."

One of the biggest barriers to women reaching leadership roles in the automobile industry is their limited representation in the management pipeline.

For Mishra, creating opportunities for women is not merely a matter of diversity but a business imperative. The CEO of Mahindra Last Mile Mobility believes as companies across sectors grapple with labour shortages, talent availability and attrition, widening the pool of women employees makes sound business sense. M&M runs a programme called SOAR, which helps women returning from career breaks of six months to three years reconnect with their careers, says Mishra.

While the transition to electric vehicles has opened up new opportunities